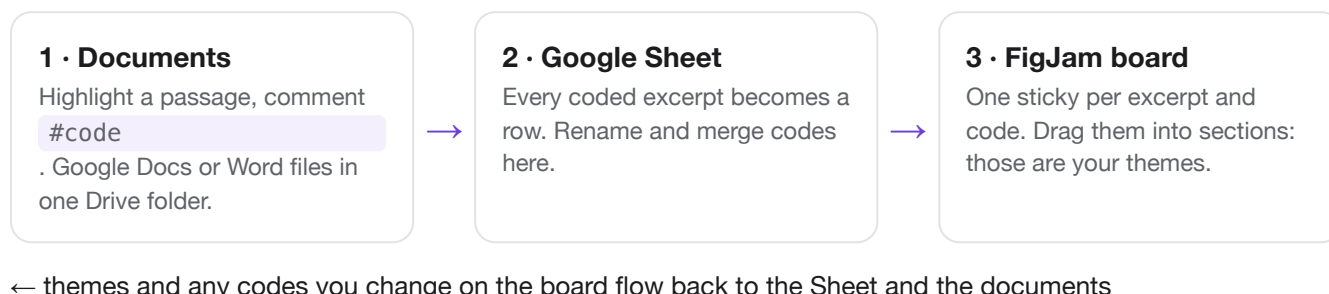


Comment-to-Code

Qualitative coding with the tools you already use. Code transcripts by commenting in Google Docs or Word, see every code gathered in a Google Sheet, and build themes together on a FigJam board.



Part 1 · Coding: for everyone	2
Part 2 · The Sheet	3
Part 3 · The board and themes	4
Part 4 · Working as a team	5
Part 5 · Setting up a new project (once, by one person)	6
Part 6 · Installing the FigJam plugin	7
Part 7 · Troubleshooting	8

Coding: for everyone

You code by commenting. There's no new app to learn and nothing to install for this part.

In the transcript

P03: Honestly? It's the only place I'm allowed to fail. Nobody grades it.

Your comment

#permission-to-fail #refuge

Studio as a place outside assessment. Compare P02.

- 1 **Open a transcript in the project folder.** Google Docs and Word (.docx) files both work.
- 2 **Highlight the passage you want to code,** then add a comment: in Google Docs, **Insert** → **Comment** or ⌘/Ctrl + Alt + M.
- 3 **Write one or more #tags , then any note you like.** The tags are your codes; everything else becomes your *memo*.
- 4 **That's it.** Within about 10 minutes the excerpt appears in the Sheet. Your project lead can also run **Coding** → **Sync now**.

Tag rules

YOU WRITE	WHAT HAPPENS
#belonging	A code. Tags start with a letter and can contain letters, numbers, <code>-</code> and <code>_</code> . Capitals don't matter: #Belonging is the same code.
#failure/ritual	A subcode : <i>ritual</i> under <i>failure</i> .
#care #voice	Two codes on one excerpt. It becomes two rows and two stickies, so each code's count is right.
A comment with no tag	Kept as an uncoded note . Useful while you're still getting to know the data.
A reply to a comment	Added to the memo, with the replier's name and date. Good for talking with a second coder.
Resolving a comment	Nothing is lost. The row stays and is marked resolved.
Deleting a comment, or removing a tag	The row is kept but greyed out with a line through it, as an audit trail.
#1 , example.com/#part	Ignored: numbers and web links aren't codes.

Changing your mind is normal. To rename a code you've used many times, don't edit every comment. Rename or merge it once in the Sheet (Part 2) or on the board (Part 3).

Working in Word? Word desktop comments are read too. When you update a file, upload it as a **new version of the same file** (in Drive: right-click → **File information** → **Manage versions** → **Upload new version**). Uploading it as a new file creates duplicate rows.

The Sheet

The Sheet opens on **Codings**. Use the **Coding** menu at the top for everything the tool does.

TAB	WHAT IT'S FOR
Codings	One row per excerpt and code: file (click to jump to the comment), excerpt, raw code, memo, author, participant, code, theme. Add your own columns to the right ; the sync never touches them.
Themes	One row per theme and sub-theme from the board: how many stickies, how many distinct codes, which codes (most frequent first) and which participants. Shows where the weight of your analysis falls.
Codes	Every code ever used. This is where you rename and merge (see below). <code>count</code> is live excerpts; <code>board_themes</code> shows where each code's stickies sit on the board.
Sources	One row per file. Fill in <code>participant</code> (e.g. P03) and it appears on every row and sticky from that file. Untick <code>include</code> to leave a file out.
Hidden: Board history, Recodes, Log	Records kept for your write-up: a dated snapshot of the board on every Sync, every recode made on the board and by whom, and every sync run. Right-click any tab → Show to see them.

code_raw and code

`code_raw` is exactly what was typed in the comment. `code` is what it means *now*. They're the same until you change your mind. Then:

- 1 Go to the Codes tab.**
- 2 Change the canonical cell.** E.g. set `belong`'s canonical to `belonging` to merge them, or set it to `sense-of-home` to rename.
- 3 Done.** Every row's `code` updates, and the stickies update on the next board Sync. The comments aren't touched, so `code_raw` keeps the history of how your coding developed.

`manual_theme` in Codes is a fallback label for excerpts that aren't on the board yet. Once a sticky sits in a theme section, the board wins. `colour` sets a code's sticky colour when the board is coloured by code (a name like `yellow` or a hex like `#ffd6a5`).

Sorting in a shared Sheet. Sorting the Codings tab reorders it for everyone. To sort or filter for yourself, use **Data** → **Create filter view** instead. Columns the sync writes show a warning if you edit them, because the next sync would overwrite your change. Change the comment, the board, or the Codes tab instead.

The board and themes

The FigJam board is where you build themes. One button, **Sync**, keeps the board, the Sheet and the documents in step. It **sends** what you've done on the board first, then **pulls** any new excerpts.

What a sticky shows

The excerpt, the participant and the code, plus the first line of the memo. There's one sticky for each excerpt and code, so the size of a cluster tells you how much sits in it.

Select a sticky and click **Open source passage** to jump to the comment in the document.

"It's the only place I'm allowed to fail."

P03 · #permission-to-fail

🔗 Studio as a place outside assessment.

Making themes

- 1 **The first Sync puts each code in its own section.** These code sections are a starting layout, not themes.
- 2 **Make a section and name it after a theme**, e.g. *Studio as refuge*. (Section tool: **S**, or from the toolbar.) Drag in stickies from *any* codes. A theme can hold as many codes and subcodes as you like, and a code can be spread across several themes.
- 3 **Put a section inside a section for a sub-theme**, e.g. *Failure as ritual* inside *Studio as refuge*. It's recorded as *Studio as refuge > Failure as ritual*.
- 4 **Or rename a code section** to a theme name. It then counts as a theme too.
- 5 **Click Sync.** The Themes tab, each row's `theme`, Codes → `board_themes` and Board history all update.

Changing a code on the board

Edit the `#tag` at the bottom of a sticky, e.g. change `#mood` to `#atmosphere`, then Sync. The change is written back into the document, and the sticky stays where it is:

- **Your project lead's own Google Doc comments** are edited in place.
- **Anyone else's comments** get a reply: `👤 #mood → #atmosphere (Sam, via board)`. Their words aren't changed, and the reply counts as the recode.
- **Word comments** are edited inside the file, which is saved as a new version. Drive keeps the old one, so any change can be undone.

Every recode is logged in the hidden **Recodes** tab: when, who, which excerpt, from, to, and how it was written.

Rules that keep the board yours

- **Sync never moves a sticky** once it's on the board. It only updates the text and colour.
- **New excerpts arrive in a section called *Unplaced (new)*.**
- **Excerpts that disappear from the Sheet** (comment deleted, tag removed) turn grey and are marked `[removed]`. They're never deleted.
- **Your own stickies, notes, drawings and arrows** are left alone. Sync ignores anything it didn't create.
- **Copy-pasting a coded sticky** makes a plain note. The original keeps the link to the data.
- **Colour stickies by theme, participant or code.** The setting is shared by everyone on the board.

Sync at the end of every session. Each Sync adds a dated snapshot to Board history, which gives you a record of how the themes developed for your reflexive account.

Working as a team

Several people can code, edit the Sheet and work on the board at the same time. What to know:

SITUATION	WHAT HAPPENS
Everyone coding in the documents	No limits. Each comment keeps its author, shown in <code>author</code> on Codings. Replies between coders go into the memo.
Two people click Sync at once	The second person is told who is syncing and asked to try again in a minute. This stops the board getting duplicate stickies.
Several boards	One board per project. The Sheet links to the first board that Syncs and refuses others. Use Coding → Unlink FigJam board to switch to a different board deliberately.
Auto-sync	Only one person needs to turn it on. If it's already running, the menu says who runs it.
Who changed a code?	Recodes on the board are logged with the Figma name of the person who made them. Board history records who ran each Sync.
Editing the board without the plugin	Anyone can open the board in the browser and move stickies, build theme sections and edit tags. Everything is picked up the next time <i>anyone</i> clicks Sync.

Linux users

Figma has no official desktop app for Linux. Until the plugin is published, it only runs in the Figma **desktop** app for Mac or Windows, so Linux users can't click **Sync** or **Open source passage**. Unofficial Linux builds of the Figma desktop app aren't supported by Figma, so don't rely on them for this.

Everything else works fully in the browser on Linux: viewing the board, moving stickies, creating and naming theme sections, nesting sub-themes, and editing tags on stickies. All of it is saved in the board and sent to the Sheet (and the documents) the next time a Mac or Windows teammate clicks Sync. So a team needs just one person with the desktop app to Sync. They don't have to be the one doing the analysis.

Once the plugin is published (privately to the organisation, or on Figma Community), it will run in the browser too, and this limit goes away.

Setting up a new project

One person does this once per project, in about 15 minutes. That person becomes the **project owner**: the web app runs under their Google account, and edits to the documents are made as them.

A. Transcripts and Sheet

- 1 **Put the anonymised transcripts in one Google Drive folder.** Subfolders are fine (e.g. one per participant). Share the folder with your team as *Commenter* or *Editor*.
- 2 **Make your own copy of the template Sheet.** Open the template link and click **Make a copy**: docs.google.com/spreadsheets/d/15pygKZGIGulipCiUQ0BFFjVLE6YvBoRMJ5xwd9jFisc/copy. Give it a project name. The copy includes the script, and starts with no settings.
- 3 **Wait for the Coding menu** to appear next to Help (reload the page if it doesn't within a few seconds).
- 4 **Click Coding → Run self-tests and allow access.** Google shows "Google hasn't verified this app" because the script is your own copy, not a published app. Click **Advanced → Go to Comment-to-Code (unsafe) → Allow**. It asks for access to Drive (to read comments and write recodes back) and to this Sheet. You should see **all tests passed**.
- 5 **Click Coding → Set watched folder...** and paste the folder's URL.
- 6 **Click Coding → Sync now.** The tabs are created and existing comments come in.
- 7 **In Sources, fill in** `participant` for each file.
- 8 **Click Coding → Start auto-sync** so new comments arrive every 10 minutes without anyone clicking.
- 9 **Share the Sheet with your team.** Anyone who will use the Coding menu needs *Editor* access and must allow access once, as in step 4.

B. Connecting FigJam

- 1 **Open the script:** in the Sheet, **Extensions → Apps Script**.
- 2 **Deploy it as a web app:** **Deploy → New deployment** → click the gear next to *Select type* → **Web app**. Set *Execute as* to **Me** and *Who has access to* **Anyone** → **Deploy** → allow access if asked.
- 3 **Copy the Web app URL** it shows (it ends in `/exec`). You can find it again later under **Deploy → Manage deployments**.
- 4 **Back in the Sheet, click Coding → FigJam connection details** and paste the URL when asked. The dialog then shows the **URL** and a **token**.
- 5 **Send the URL and token privately** to the teammates who will run Sync (e.g. by direct message, not in a public channel).
- 6 **Create the project's FigJam board** and share it with the team as *Can edit*.

Keep the token private. Anyone with the URL and token can read the coded excerpts. If it's shared too widely, click **Coding → Rotate FigJam token** and send the new one to the team.

Installing the FigJam plugin

Only the people who click **Sync** need this, and only on **Mac or Windows**. Everyone else can use the board in the browser.

- 1 **Install the Figma desktop app** from figma.com/downloads and sign in.
- 2 **Download the plugin package** `Comment-to-Code-FigJam-plugin.zip` (from your project lead) and unzip it somewhere permanent, e.g. your Documents folder. Figma loads the plugin from this folder, so don't delete or move it afterwards.
- 3 **Open the project's FigJam board** in the desktop app. You need to be on the board itself, not the Figma home screen.
- 4 **Right-click an empty part of the canvas** → **Plugins** → **Development** → **Import plugin from manifest...** and choose `manifest.json` inside the unzipped folder.
- 5 **Run it:** right-click → **Plugins** → **Development** → **Comment-to-Code**.
- 6 **Paste the Web app URL and token** from your project lead (Part 5 B) and click **Sync**. The URL and token are remembered next time.

"File format not recognized or failed to convert"? The file was opened with **File** → **Import** or dragged into Figma, which expects design files. Use the plugin import in step 4, from *inside* a board.

Updating the plugin: when you get a new package, unzip it over the old folder and run the plugin again. There's no need to re-import.

Troubleshooting

PROBLEM	FIX
No Coding menu	Reload the Sheet and wait a few seconds. If it still doesn't show, open Extensions → Apps Script once, then reload.
"Google hasn't verified this app"	Expected for your own copy: Advanced → Go to Comment-to-Code (unsafe) → Allow .
A comment isn't in the Sheet	Auto-sync runs every 10 minutes; Coding → Sync now is instant. Check the file is in the watched folder, its <code>include</code> box in Sources is ticked, and the comment was actually saved. An edited comment only saves when you click Save .
Rows look out of date after a tool update	Coding → Full re-sync re-reads every comment. Rows are updated, not duplicated.
Plugin: <i>Failed to fetch</i>	The URL is wrong. Copy it from Deploy → Manage deployments (ends in <code>/exec</code>), and check that <i>Who has access</i> is Anyone . If the Sheet's dialog shows an old URL, use Coding → Reset web app URL .
Plugin: <i>bad token</i>	The token has been rotated. Get the current one from Coding → FigJam connection details .
Plugin: <i>linked to another board</i>	Each Sheet serves one board. Sync from that board, or Coding → Unlink FigJam board to switch.
Plugin: <i>... is syncing this board right now</i>	A teammate's Sync is in progress. Try again in a minute.
Plugin: <i>△ ... not found as plain text in the Word comment</i>	Word split the tag across formatting, so it can't be edited safely. Change the tag in the document itself, then Sync.
No Development item in the Plugins menu	You're in Figma in a browser. Development plugins need the desktop app (Part 6). On Linux, see Part 4.
A sticky shows <code>[removed]</code>	Its comment was deleted or the tag removed in the document. Delete the sticky if you don't need it, or restore the tag in the document to bring it back.
Something went wrong with a document	Drive keeps every version: File → Version history (Google Docs) or Manage versions (Word files). The Recodes tab shows what the board changed and when.

Quick reference

In documents

`#code` code · `#code/sub` subcode
 text after tags = memo · replies = memo
 no tag = uncoded note

On the board

named section = theme · section in section = sub-theme
 edit `#tag` on a sticky = recode (written back)
Sync = send board, then pull new excerpts